THE VIEW FROM NEW DELHI

The perceived pros and cons for India arising out of Dissanayake's win in the presidential polls

POSITIVES

- **Dissanayake visited India in February on New Delhi's invitation and met external affairs minister S. Jaishankar and national security advisor Ajit Doval**
- **He went to the Amul plant in Gujarat during the visit, evincing interest in a similar milk cooperative system for Lanka**
- **He has vowed to maintain good relations with India, acknowledging its importance in the neighbourhood and region**
- **He has repeatedly acknowledged New Delhi's generous, and crucial, aid grant of $4 billion to Sri Lanka during the 2022 economic crisis**

CHALLENGES

- **Dissanayake took part in protests against Indian "interference" in the '80s. Given JVP's ties with China, he is seen to be close to Beijing. India must guard against a rise in Chinese influence in Lanka**
- **He opposes the 13th amendment of the constitution—a result of the India–Sri Lanka Accord, which devolves some power to the Tamil minority**
- **He wants to review Adani wind power project, says it violates Lanka's "energy sovereignty"**
- **Fate of the India–Sri Lanka Economic Partnership Vision signed in 2023 by Ranil Wickeremesinghe, as well as land bridge between the two nations, is uncertain**

dress to the nation after he was sworn in, Dissanayake admitted that he was not a magician and the "general public and people from all walks of life too have a great responsibility" to help and support him in his endeavour to end the economic crisis.

Apart from urgent economic tasks, with the NPP having just three MPs in Parliament, among Dissanayake's first decisions was to dissolve Parliament and call for fresh elections to be held by mid-November. He also appointed NPP MP Harini Amarasuriya, a respected academic and activist, as prime minister, a move that is also likely to win over women's votes. It is crucial that the NPP wins a majority in Parliament to keep the party's promise of amending the constitution to curb the "excessive powers" of the president and to bring about equitable devolution of powers to the provinces. But it's going to be a tough task for the NPP to win the 113 seats needed for a simple majority out of the total 225 parliamentary seats, especially if the SJB and the UNP enter into a seat-sharing arrangement—such a move could give them a much higher vote share than what they got individually in the presidential polls.



Dissanayake has appointed NPP MP Harini Amarasuriya as PM, a move that is likely to win over women's votes

Despite his socialist leanings, Dissanayake is pragmatic enough to know that he has to attract foreign investors and domestic private investors to pull the economy out of the doldrums. In his speech at the release of the party's manifesto before the election, he talked of three major priorities: maximise the country's economic production and provide jobs; extend support to industrialists, traders and foreign investors to rebuild the economy; and focus on reviving key sectors, including manufacturing, tourism and the marine industry. As he said, "We will tell every investor, both local and foreign, to bring their proposals without hesitation. We only care whether the project benefits the country." He has also committed to improve the education and health sectors. Overall, he aims to create "a rich country and a beautiful life" for every citizen.

For India, it is Dissanayake's foreign policy that is of much interest and concern. The new president has talked of ensuring "a strong and stable foreign policy" that will not "allow the use of our territorial waters, land or air in any manner that poses a threat to national security and ensuring that all economic transactions benefit the country". Unlike in Bangladesh, where India had solely backed the Sheikh Hasina regime, in Sri Lanka, the ministry of external affairs had ensured that good relations were maintained with all the key parties and their leaders. During the economic crisis, India earned much goodwill by giving timely financial aid of close to $5 billion. Dissanayake even visited India this February and met national security advisor Ajit Doval and external affairs minister S. Jaishankar, apart from travelling to Gujarat and Kerala. He was keenly interested in understanding how the Amul cooperative functions and wanted to replicate the dairy industry model in Sri Lanka.

In private conversations, Dissanayake has reportedly said he understands the importance of India as a key player in the geopolitical context and as a trading partner and is keen to enhance bilateral relations. However, he has openly stated that he would review the $10 billion Adani project to set up wind energy power plants in Lanka. The NPP's proximity to China and Dissanayake's close relations with the Chinese Communist Party are cause for concern and India will have to wait and watch as to how the new president will balance his country's foreign relations with the various competing forces. Having backed the Aragalaya movement in 2022, Dissanayake is well aware of how volatile citizens' opinions are and that if he is unable to deliver in the next year, it just might turn again him. ■